Historical years, territory and the estimation sample

Controls: Year of the Historical Territory; Historical Territory; Year of the Historical Population or Population Density; Historical Instrument Year (State).

1. The two historical years have different roles. The territory year determines historical sample availability. For counties and MSAs, it also determines the historical state or territory classification used for historical fixed effects. The instrument year chooses the census population used to explain modern employment or density. Both years run from 1790 to 1900 in ten-year steps. Modern GDP and employment come from the separately selected modern year.

For example, selecting territory year 1790 and instrument year 1900 requires usable historical data in both years. The regression uses the 1900 instrument, but changing that year alone does not replace the 1790 historical fixed effects. The chosen matching method is used to check availability in both years. OLS retains this historical availability restriction so that the comparison with IV is more closely aligned.

2. Scope refers to historical source areas. *Historical States Only* includes source areas that were states at the relevant census date. *Historical States & Territories* also includes U.S. territories. This does not mean that the modern destination state must already have existed. A location in modern West Virginia, for example, can receive historical population from Virginia. The same scope choice is applied separately in the territory year and instrument year.

3. Wider historical coverage need not increase the final sample. A larger scope can introduce a source area with an unknown population or a known reporting gap. For population instruments, this can make a total unavailable. The historical CH instrument instead averages the known populations and requires at least 80% coverage by areas with known population and usable geometry. Recorded zeros count toward coverage; unknown populations do not. Source areas crossing modern state borders are split by geographic overlap. Missing records do not separately exclude a state meeting this rule. State area-weighted population requires 95% geographic coverage, under its separate population-availability rules. The State analysis covers the 48 contiguous modern states, excluding Alaska, Hawaii and the District of Columbia.

4. The regression applies further requirements. The final sample needs the outcome, instrument, selected controls and any required fixed-effect identity. CH also requires complete county inputs. Missing values are not zeros. A log instrument requires a positive value. Thus, changing an instrument, control or adjustment can change both the estimate and the observations behind it. Use the reported observation count and data notes when comparing results; a later census alone does not guarantee a larger estimation sample.